

Socialist Realism

Socialist Realism (not to be confused with Social Realism) was conceived as 'the representation of the proletarian revolution' and produced as communist propaganda. It was a type of realistic art established by Joseph Stalin (1878–1953) in the Soviet Union, with style and content intended to further the goals of socialism and communism, and its influence spread to other socialist countries. By 1934, all independent or avant-garde art groups in the USSR were abolished, and only official, Socialist Realism was allowed, created to be understood by the masses of illiterate Russians and to portray their courage and struggles against adversity, inciting hope, patriotism, revolutionary action and productivity.

In its attempt to build socialism and a classless society, the art celebrates the workers, using naturalistic idealization to portray ordinary Russians as brave, resolute, young, healthy and reliable. Although intended to be lifelike, the imagery was not credible, and the style came to an end with the fall of the Soviet Union in 1991.



Statues in Budapest Szoborpark, 1950s